mujahideen may attack Jalalabad. Gul and his trusted friends in the CIA had promised Hekmatyar that he would become prime minister of Afghanistan after Jalalabad was captured. Though it could not be verified as a fact, our agents in Peshawar reported that the US ambassador to Pakistan, Robert B. Oakley, had been present at a high-level meeting of Pakistani officials where it was decided to besiege Jalalabad,' Ashfaq said.

The R&AW intelligence was not a hundred per cent accurate as far as the strength of insurgents was concerned, but the attack on Jalalabad in the wee hours of 5 March 1989 duly took place. The forces led by the Hekmatyar faction captured the Jalalabad air base the same day. Afghan soldiers surrendered and were executed by the mujahideen. However, Najibullah's government had been prepared for this. It was not going to be an easy battle for the holy warriors. The Afghan army retaliated and the siege ended two months later in a humiliating defeat for the fighters of the seven-party alliance.

A Marxist newspaper called Spartacist Canada published an eye-grabbing headline on 12 May 1989: 'Afghanistan Smash CIA's Cutthroats!' The paper quoted various sources in its report that Afghan government troops had broken out of the besieged city of Jalalabad and were recapturing positions taken by the mujahideen, whose strategy was in disarray. It said: 'For Washington and its allies, this is a humiliating setback to their plans to rout the Soviet-backed Afghan government and reimpose a regime of Mullah, Tribal Chiefs and landlords on the long-suffering peoples of this country. But, the danger is far from over. While the rebels' morale is flagging, their paymasters in Washington want more blood.'